CHAPTER FIVE

THE STEPPING STONE

JRD the Indefatigable

J.R.D. Tata steered the Tata Group from a fourteen-unit enterprise to a ninety-five-unit organization, dealing in a variety of products and services. During his tenure, he increased the combined sales of the Tata Group from Rs 280 crore in 1938 to over Rs 2,000 crore in 1980–81, a more than seven-fold increase in just over four decades. He attained the status of a legend, pioneering several innovative changes, contributing to the group's growth and India's industrialization while unflinchingly adhering to the highest ethical standards in the conduct of business.

In 1962, when JRD completed forty years with the group, Lady Tata acknowledged his contribution to the organization by writing to him stating: 'May I, therefore, take this opportunity of saying how grateful we are to you for the way in which you have steered the ship of Tatas through calm and storm since the death of Sir Naoroji Saklatvala. On your tender shoulders, at an early age, you have carried the burden of running the vast network of Tata organisation, in a truly Tata Tradition of integrity and fair play so effectively.'

By 1980, JRD was seventy-six and had spent forty-two years at the group's apex. Though he had appointed Ratan as the head of TIL in October 1981, he continued steering Tata Sons and its companies with apparently ageless determination.

Towards the end of the 1980s, however, it was evident that the years had taken their toll. The fatigue had started to show. Yet, JRD was neither prepared nor willing to surrender to it. This could not have been more evident than in his unwavering resolve to re-enact in 1982 what he had done fifty years ago on 15 October 1932, when he had flown the first Tata